

The Cold War

After World War II, two superpowers had different ideas about how to run the world. The communist USSR wanted everybody to be equal. The capitalist United States thought it was more important for people to be free. There was a Cold War, with America and the USSR taking opposite sides in struggles around the world between 1947 and 1991.

The Space Race

America and the USSR raced each other to get into space. The United States won when Neil Armstrong became the first person on the moon in 1969.



ARCTIC OCEAN

Radar stations along the Distance Early Warning (DEW) line would warn of a USSR bomber attack.

DEW line

NATO flag

The North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO) was an alliance led by the United States, set up in 1949.

KEY

NATO

Countries that were part of NATO—a capitalist group led by the United States.

Warsaw Pact

Communist countries that were part of the Warsaw Pact—an agreement with the USSR.

Non-NATO and Warsaw Pact

Countries that did not take part in the Cold War.

Conflicts

Foreign civil wars where the United States and the USSR supported different sides.

Uprisings

Revolts against governments in communist countries in Europe.

Spies

Places where spies operated.

NORTH AMERICA

ATLANTIC OCEAN

Intercontinental ballistic missiles

Intercontinental missiles could carry nuclear warheads to destroy cities thousands of miles away.

Eisenhower and Khrushchev meet

In 1959 US President Eisenhower and the USSR's Secretary Khrushchev met to try to reduce the tension.

America and the USSR almost went to war when the USSR placed nuclear weapons in Cuba in 1962.

Cuban Missile Crisis

The United States funded rebels fighting the radical government of Nicaragua between 1978 and 1979.

Nicaraguan Revolution

The hydrogen bomb

The first nuclear bomb was created during World War II. This atomic bomb was the most powerful weapon in history. During the Cold War, both sides developed an even more destructive nuclear bomb, called the hydrogen bomb.



First hydrogen bomb test, 1952